

Department of Agricultural, Food, and Resource Economics College of Agriculture and Natural Resources

AFRE 435: Financial Management for the Bioeconomy

Fall 2026 Syllabus

Part 1: Course Information

Instructor Information

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Office Hours: Tuesday and Thursday, 2:30 – 3:30 and by appointment

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Course Description

This course deals with the fundamental problems of financial management for corporate agribusiness firms. Emphasis will be placed on concepts including financial statement analysis, security markets, time value of money, evaluating stocks and bonds, interest rates, and risk analysis. The course will also cover how managers can help maximize their firm's value by improving decisions with working capital management, capital budgeting, and choice of capital structure. Examples will be incorporated for applications of financial management principles to farms and small business.

Prerequisites

Required: ACC 201 or ACC 230 or AFRE 130

Recommended: (STT 200 or STT 201 or STT 315) and MTH 124

Textbook & Course Materials

Ross, S. A., Westerfield, R.W., and Jordan, B. D. *Essentials of Corporate Finance*, 11th edition, McGraw Hill, 2025.

We will be using the **Connect** platform for this course. Your Connect account hosts the full eBook and assignments. See D2L for the procedure to get connected. Readings from the eBook will be posted to D2L and assigned as the semester progresses.

Course Requirements

- Internet connection (DSL, LAN, or cable connection desirable)
- Access to Desire2Learn (D2L). It is your responsibility to check the site regularly, as I will frequently post materials and updates. Please ensure your email address is correctly set up in D2L to receive important messages. I will upload presentations and related materials to the website prior to each class.
- Connect to McGraw Hill online textbook

- iClicker. If you haven't already joined iClicker, please do so and take time to familiarize yourself with the platform.

Course Structure

This course will be delivered in-person. Course materials, including slides, will be posted online through the course management system and you will need your MSU NetID to login to the course from the D2L homepage (<http://d2l.msu.edu>). In class, lessons will include lectures, interactive activities from the online resources, in-class quizzes, hands-on assignments, a group project with oral presentations at the end of the semester, and two exams.

Bring your laptop, tablet, or smartphone to class every day. We will be regularly using Excel for financial calculations, so a laptop is highly recommended. You have access to the full suite of Microsoft products, including Excel, through MSU365.

Technical Assistance

If you need technical assistance at any time during the course or to report a problem you can:

- Visit the [MSU Libraries Discovery Services Site \(https://lib.msu.edu/dls/\)](https://lib.msu.edu/dls/)
- Visit the [Desire2Learn Help Site \(https://help.d2l.msu.edu/\)](https://help.d2l.msu.edu/)
- Visit the MSU IT Help & Support Site (<https://tech.msu.edu/support/help/>) or email ithelp@msu.edu

Resource Center for Persons with Disabilities (RCPD)

- To make an appointment with a specialist, contact (517) 884-7273 or text: (517) 355-1293
- Website for RCPD: <https://www.rcpd.msu.edu/>

Part 2: Course Objectives and Learning Outcomes

In this course, participants will gain knowledge and experience in:

- Understanding of firms' financial management concepts, scope, and environment
- Diagnosing firms' financial strengths and weaknesses
- Skills and tools for financial decision making
- Effective communication

This course will help students develop analytical, critical thinking, and communication skills in the core areas of financial management.

By successfully completing this course, students should be able to:

1. Understand firms' financial management
2. Analyze risks and derivatives in financial markets
3. Evaluate firms' financial strategies
4. Make data-driven financial decisions
5. Communicate financial suggestions effectively

You will meet the objectives listed above through a combination of the following activities in this course:

- Attending lectures and participate in class activities, including hands-on practice and quizzes.
 - In-class quizzes will be short (5 minute), given periodically during class periods; quiz dates will not always be announced in advance. They will consist of simple multiple-choice or fill-in-the-blank questions. No makeup quizzes will be provided for ANY reason, although I will drop your lowest two quiz scores, including missed ones.
 - We will additionally be using iClicker for more frequent comprehension checks as we work through problems in class. Working through financial calculations together and on your own in class is a key component of this course; bring your laptops with Excel every day. Template spreadsheets will be provided to download from D2L and the Connect platform.
- Completing and submitting assignments through the online Connect platform. These are to be typed rather than hand written.
- Completing textbook readings and interactive activities. There are additional comprehension checks that are very helpful as you do the readings, although these will not be graded.
- Two exams, taken in-class. Computer software will be needed for some parts of the exams. Outside of exceptional circumstances, no makeup exams will be given.
- A capstone project, conducting financial analysis for a firm in the bioeconomy of your choice. This project will be conducted in groups of up to 4 students, working together throughout the semester. More guidance on the project will be provided in class during the semester. It will culminate in an oral presentation of about 10

minutes to the class at the end of the semester, although intermediate submissions will be graded for completion to help ensure progress. You may choose your own group members; I will assign groups for those who do not form their own group. You will also submit an evaluation of your group members at the end of the semester, which I will use in assigning individual grades for the project.

Part 3: Course Outline/Schedule

Important Note: Refer to D2L or the 'business' lecture slide for specific meeting dates and times, and readings to be completed before class. If you have any questions, please contact your instructor. Note that the exact dates are subject to change.

The table below describes the course activities including topics, readings, and assignments due.

<i>Date</i>	<i>Topic</i>	<i>Reading</i>	<i>Deliverables</i>
<i>Sept 1</i>	Intro & Foundations	Ch 1	
<i>Sept 3</i>	Accounting Review	Ch 2	
<i>Sept 8</i>	Accounting Review		Homework 1
<i>Sept 10</i>	Cash Flow & Ratio Analysis	Ch 3	
<i>Sept 15</i>	Cash Flow & Ratio Analysis		Homework 2
<i>Sept 17</i>	Cash Flow & Ratio Analysis		Group Names
<i>Sept 22</i>	Guest Lecture		
<i>Sept 24</i>	Time Value of Money	Ch 4	Firm Name
<i>Sept 29</i>	Discounted Cash Flow Valuation	Ch 5	Homework 3
<i>Oct 1</i>	Discounted Cash Flow Valuation		Homework 4
<i>Oct 6</i>	Review		Balance Sheets
<i>Oct 8</i>	Exam 1		Homework 5
<i>Oct 13</i>	Bonds	Ch 6	
<i>Oct 15</i>	Bonds		
<i>Oct 20</i>	Stocks	Ch 7	
<i>Oct 22</i>	Stocks		Homework 6
<i>Oct 27</i>	<i>Fall Break – No Class</i>		
<i>Oct 29</i>	Net Present Value	Ch 8	Excel with Calculations
<i>Nov 3</i>	Net Present Value		Homework 7
<i>Nov 5</i>	Capital Investment Decisions	Ch 9	
<i>Nov 10</i>	Capital Investment Decisions		Homework 8
<i>Nov 12</i>	Risk & Return	Ch 11	
<i>Nov 17</i>	Risk & Return		Homework 9
<i>Nov 19</i>	Cost of Capital	Ch 12	Draft of PPT
<i>Nov 24</i>	Cost of Capital		Homework 10
<i>Nov 26</i>	<i>Thanksgiving – No Class</i>		
<i>Dec 1</i>	Presentations		Homework 11, Final PPT
<i>Dec 3</i>	Presentations		
<i>Dec 8</i>	Wrap-up/Review		Peer Evaluation
<i>Dec 10</i>	Exam 2		

Part 4: Grading Policy

Graded Course Activities

The table below describes the graded course activities including weights and activity description. The first column includes the share of the total grade, and the second column includes a description for each activity.

<i>Weight</i>	<i>Description</i>
10%	In-Class Quizzes (Best 8 out of 10)
20%	Assignments (11)
40%	Exams (2)
10%	Participation and Attendance
20%	Capstone Project
100	Total

Late Work Policy

The schedule of assignments is designed to allow us to progress through the content of the course, and build on earlier topics. In particular, deadlines allow for feedback on your work, so that you can improve and study. However, I understand that circumstances may arise which make a particular deadline difficult for you to meet. If you feel you cannot meet a particular deadline for an assignment, you must let me know in advance of the deadline using D2L (“submitting” your explanation in the assignment submission portal), and set a new deadline for yourself. If you let me know in advance of the original deadline, there will be no grade penalty so long as you submit before your adjusted deadline. If you do not let me know in advance of the deadline, you will receive a 0 on that assignment.

Artificial Intelligence Policy

You are welcome to use generative AI tools on most take-home assignments, but not quizzes. You are responsible for the information you submit based on an AI query (for example, that it does not violate intellectual property laws, or contain misinformation or unethical content). You are responsible for fact checking information provided by AI models. Your use of AI tools must be properly documented and cited in order to stay within University policies on academic integrity and the Spartan Code of Honor Academic Pledge. AI is unlikely to generate a response that would be seen as quality work, so should always be supervised, modified, and improved. Recall you are at university to acquire the skills you need to succeed in the labor market; the assignments are designed to help you inculcate these skills. Use your judgment as to what extent AI is accelerating your learning or preventing you from acquiring critical skills.

At the end of assignments for which you use AI tools, provide a statement describing how you used AI tools. For example, “Chat GPT was used to check grammar and conduct background research on the context.”

Viewing Grades

I will use the Grade feature of D2L to record your scores. It is your responsibility to verify that these scores are properly recorded. Final grades may be curved, but your grade will never fall as

a result of the curve. Total points will be calculated based on the table above with weights for each category given.

Grade Point Assignment (Grading Scale)

The table below describes the relationships between grade point, percent, and performance. The first column identifies the grade point. The second column describes the percentage associated with that grade point. There will be no rounding: for example, a 91.6 is 3.5, not 4.0.

<i>Grade Point</i>	<i>Points Earned</i>
4.0	≥92%
3.5	85% to 91.9%
3.0	80% to 84.9%
2.5	75% to 79.9%
2.0	70% to 74.9%
1.5	65% to 69.9%
1.0	60% to 64.9%
0.0	<60%

Part 5: Course Policies

Commit to Integrity: Academic Honesty

Article 2. III.B.2 of the [Academic Freedom Report](#) states that "The student shares with the faculty the responsibility for maintaining the integrity of scholarship, grades, and professional standards." In addition, AFRE adheres to the policies on academic honesty as specified in General Student Regulations 1.0, Protection of Scholarship and Grades; the all-University Policy on Integrity of Scholarship and Grades; and Ordinance 17.00, Examinations. (See [Spartan Life: Student Handbook and Resource Guide](#) and/or the MSU Web site: www.msu.edu.)

Therefore, unless authorized by your instructor, you are expected to complete all course assignments, including homework, lab work, quizzes, tests and exams, without assistance from any source. You are expected to develop original work for this course; therefore, you may not submit course work you completed for another course to satisfy the requirements for this course. Also, you are not authorized to use the www.allmsu.com Web site to complete any course work in this course. Students who violate MSU academic integrity rules may receive a penalty grade, including a failing grade on the assignment or in the course. Contact your instructor if you are unsure about the appropriateness of your course work. (See also the [Academic Integrity](#) webpage.)

Academic integrity is one of the highest values that Michigan State holds. We all operate under the Spartan Code of Honor Academic Pledge: "As a Spartan, I will strive to uphold values of the highest ethical standard. I will practice honesty in my work, foster honesty in my peers, and take pride in knowing that honor in ownership is worth more than grades."

Use of Artificial Intelligence (AI)

We are living in an exciting time when artificial intelligence can help us create new things, such as text, images, music, or code, from existing data and models. This is called generative AI, and it has many possibilities for improving our education. We can use it to enhance our learning, spark our creativity, and try new ways of teaching and testing.

Michigan State University does not have a blanket policy for use of AI in courses. As an student, you should follow the policies of your instructor.

[CANR Resources for AI](#)

Inform Your Instructor of Any Accommodations Needed

From the Resource Center for Persons with Disabilities (RCPD): Michigan State University is committed to providing equal opportunity for participation in all programs, services and activities. Requests for accommodations by persons with disabilities may be made by contacting the Resource Center for Persons with Disabilities at 517-884-RCPD or on the web at rcpd.msu.edu. Once your eligibility for an accommodation has been determined, you will be issued a Verified Individual Services Accommodation ("VISA") form. Please present this form to me at the start of the term and/or two weeks prior to the accommodation date (test, project, etc.). Requests received after this date may not be honored.

Participation and Engagement

During all classes, the instructor expects students to be fully engaged and prepared to discuss reading assignments. Students are encouraged to ask questions of the instructor, guest speakers, and their peers.

Active participation includes, but is not limited to, the following behaviors:

1. Asking and answering questions of the instructors, peers, or guest speakers
2. Bringing forth new ideas, information, or perspectives to academic conversations
3. Discussing your readings and reflections with instructors and peers
4. Meeting with the instructors to discuss your interests, assignments, or project
5. Questioning information presented and discussed
6. Participating in small group discussions and activities
7. Assuming responsibility for personal behavior and learning

Attendance Policy: Attendance will be graded using iClicker during normal class periods, and may be taken separately when there are guest speakers. Both will count towards your attendance grade. It is your responsibility to contact me if you have extenuating circumstances.

Technology use: We will use iClicker in class, which is free for students but requires either a phone or computer during class. We will also use Excel in class for financial calculations.

Complete Assignments

Assignments for this course will be submitted electronically through D2L unless otherwise instructed. Assignments must be submitted before midnight on the given deadline or special permission must be requested from instructor before the due date.

Etiquette and Communication

Classes will involve a mixture of lecture, discussion, and group or individual practice, and will be in-person. Cellphones should be set to silent. Be respectful of your peers in behavior and language both inside and outside of class, on email, and social media. Practice professional etiquette when emailing the class and me. Feel free to email me anytime, but do not save important questions for last-minute emails! I check email routinely (but not constantly) on weekdays between 9-5; expect a 24 hour response time. Although you are always welcome to come talk to me before or after class, it's generally helpful to follow up with an email to make sure I have the information in the correct place.

Please call me either Professor Meinzen-Dick or Dr. Meinzen-Dick. My preferred pronouns are she/her. Over email, I will generally call you by the first name that appears in your email address or D2L account, unless you let me know that you prefer a different name (in which case I am very happy to use your preferred name). I will try to default to they/them pronouns to refer to students, but if you have other preferred pronouns, please feel free to let me know via email.

We wish to foster a safe learning environment. All opinions and experiences, no matter how different or controversially they may be perceived, must be respected in the tolerant spirit of academic discourse. You are encouraged to comment, question, or critique an idea; but you are not to attack any individual. Working as a community of learners, we can build a polite and respectful course ambiance. Please keep the following in mind for this course:

- Do not dominate any discussion. Give other students the opportunity to join in the discussion.
- Do not use offensive language. Present ideas appropriately.
- Avoid using slang language. This could lead to misinterpretation.
- Keep an open mind and be willing to express even your minority opinions.
- Think and edit before you speak or write to your classmates and me.
- Do not hesitate to ask for feedback.

PART 6: General College and University Policies

All other general college and university policies applicable to this course are available at <https://www.canr.msu.edu/facultystaff/policies>. Please review these policies.

Topics covered in these general policies include:

- Students with disabilities, Resource Center for Persons with Disabilities (RCPD) and accommodations
- Student rights under the family educational rights and privacy act (FERPA)
 - Student release authorization form
- Religious holiday policies
- Grief absence policies
- Students in distress policies
- MSU student athlete policies
- Course add-drop policies
- Honors options
- Course Management system policies
- Final exam policy and attendance
- Grade dispute policies
- Academic honesty and integrity, plagiarism, and disciplinary procedures
- Disruptive behavior
- Harassment and discrimination policies
- RVSM University reporting protocols
- Limits to confidentiality
- Social media policy
- Web accessibility policies
- MSU Code of Teaching Responsibility
- SIRS
- Commercialization of lecture notes
- University Learning Goals

Counseling and Psychiatric Services (CAPS): College students often experience issues that may interfere with academic success such as academic stress, sleep problems, juggling responsibilities, life events, relationship concerns, or feelings of anxiety, hopelessness, or depression. If you or a friend is struggling, we strongly encourage you to seek support. Helpful, effective resources are available on campus, and most are free of charge.

- If you are struggling with this class, please check-in during office hours or contact me by email at meinzend@msu.edu.
- Check-in with your academic advisor if you are struggling in multiple classes, unsure whether you are making the most of your time at MSU, or unsure what academic resources are available at MSU.
- Access CAPS Services for new counseling and psychiatric services by making a **CAPS Phone Request: CAPS is providing remote crisis services 24/7/365. Students can call us at 517-355-8270 and press "1" at the prompt to speak with a crisis counselor.** Other prompt options are available for those not in crisis.
- Visit <https://caps.msu.edu> for additional information and resources.